> THE GRATITUDE OF EVERY HOME ON OUR ISLAND ... GOES OUT TO THE BRITISH AIRMEN WHO ARE TURNING THE TIDE OF WORLD WAR ... NEVER IN THE FIELD OF HUMAN CONFLICT WAS SO MUCH OWED BY SO MANY TO SO FEW.
>
> **WINSTON CHURCHILL**, PRIME MINISTER OF GREAT BRITAIN

228m (250yd) rather than the 366m (400yd) normal at the start of the conflict. There were always squadrons that fought by the book, however, entering combat and manoeuvring in the rigid formations of the prewar years, often with disastrous consequences.

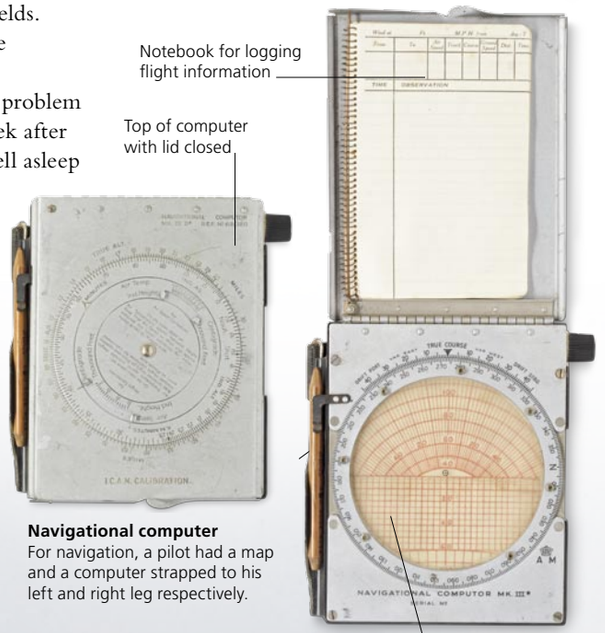
WAR OF ATTRITION

The RAF was aided by the fact that the Luftwaffe's campaign suffered from a certain lack of clarity. Radar stations and aircraft factories should have been top of the German target list, yet they were soon neglected in favour of raids on airfields. Then, German bombers and escorts were engaged by almost 700 RAF fighters.

Physical exhaustion became a serious problem as almost daily combat was sustained week after week. Pilots became so exhausted they fell asleep in their cockpits while returning from missions. At times there was little rest on the ground, as airfields were bombed and strafed by the Luftwaffe. The constant stress of battle was hard for anyone to cope with – Ginger Lacey may have been a fighter ace, but he always vomitted before taking off for combat. By mid-September most pilots in front-line squadrons had been shot down at least once. As the battle



Celebrating victory
Pilots from a Spitfire squadron celebrate with bottles of wine after fighting over France in 1944. Some Battle of Britain fighter pilots saw action through to the end of the war.



Navigational computer
For navigation, a pilot had a map and a computer strapped to his left and right leg respectively.